

Freight logistics & last-mile delivery in Spain

Sector context for a consulting discovery exercise · Spain, 2024–2026

Spain's freight and last-mile sector is growing in volume but operating under tighter margins, stricter urban rules and persistent labour shortages. For medium-sized operators, competitive advantage increasingly depends on planning quality, cleaner operational data and better visibility once vehicles leave the hub.

Market at a glance: 1.335bn parcel items · €158.9k annual operating cost for a 40T truck · 62% of cost from fuel + personnel · 10% driver vacancy rate

WHAT IS CHANGING

- Parcel demand keeps expanding, while customers expect tighter delivery windows and more reliable service.
- Low Emission Zones are reshaping urban fleet choices and route design, especially in Madrid.
- Fuel, labour and subcontractor costs continue to pressure margins, increasing the value of efficient routing and exception management.
- Driver shortages make it harder to scale through headcount alone and increase dependence on experienced planners and flexible capacity.

HOW THE WORK TYPICALLY RUNS

- Orders move from ERP/WMS into planning, dispatch, fleet assignment, delivery, proof-of-delivery and exception handling.
- Many mid-market operators still combine legacy systems with Excel, phone calls, email and messaging apps.
- The hardest moments are dynamic: bad addresses, traffic, absent recipients, route imbalances, vehicle range limits and same-day changes.

AI & ANALYTICS ALREADY IN USE

- SEUR Predict uses data-driven prediction to narrow delivery windows and improve customer visibility.
- Paack has applied routing and scheduling technology to dense urban delivery operations.
- Routal and similar SaaS tools help smaller operators replace part of spreadsheet-heavy route planning.
- Large operators such as Logista/NACEX combine analytics, automation and warehouse technology for planning and peak operations.

CLIENT LENS — IBERIANEX LOGISTICS S.A. (FICTIONAL)

- Coslada-based operator combining pallet freight into Madrid with B2B/B2C last-mile distribution.
- 18 tractor units, 45 vans and a flexible pool of 25–40 freelance drivers.
- Legacy ERP + basic TMS; morning planning can still require around three hours of spreadsheet work.
- In the most difficult residential zones, first-attempt delivery failures can reach about 14%, while customer service has limited live visibility once vans leave the hub.

CONSULTING TAKEAWAY

The opportunity is not simply to “add AI”. The strongest use cases are the ones that improve planning, visibility and exception handling on top of reliable operational data — while keeping planners and drivers in control.

Sources: CNMC parcel/postal reporting; MITMA Road Freight Cost Observatory; Madrid 360 / ZBE context; IRU/FENADISMER workforce context; SEUR, Paack, Routal and Logista/NACEX examples. IberiaNex figures are fictional scenario assumptions.